Collection on Cancer

By Robert W. King, Mark Ritvo and Steve Kantor

Touching the Floor

I touch my palms to the floor
and granite rhinos surge up my arms
and lock in my shoulders.
Water flecks on my back
and my head is shaved
by bladed cream.

But then my time in my body is up
and it's time for my mind:
It seeks wisdom
and the rhinos fall into a well,
their faces falling apart—

I want to know what their last words are
but their lips are fading into the purple.

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I put my hands into the ground again
but rhinos come only for the body
and never for the mind.

I used to want infinite time with my thoughts.
Now I'd prefer to give all my time
to a body that's dying
from cancer.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Max Ritvo
Book: Four Reincarnations: Poems (Pg 65)
ISBN: 978-1571314901
Publisher: Milkweed Editions
Date (Month/Year): October 4, 2016

NOTE: Also found on Poets.org (Approved NDSA website) at https://poets.org/poem/touching-floor

INTRODUCTION

Cancer has traditionally been the diagnosis people fear most. But is dying from cancer so much worse than the alternatives? The advantage of death from cancer is that while it is possible to live with this disease for a long time, the dying process happens relatively fast, yet slow enough to give time for yourself and those around you to prepare for your death and say goodbye. This collection imagines cancer through various metaphors . . . but in the end, cancer takes on its own voiced persona and speaks to us directly. A Collection on Cancer by Robert W. King, Mark Ritvo and Steve Kantor.

Embedding the Cancer Port

It's called a port, a harbor, haven, home,
a city on the coast of my chest opened
for a passage into my heart—which we say
is where emotions live—and it's embedded,

slipped into a shallow nest of flesh, a bump,
a lump under the skin on the right so
the narrow street can reach the marketplace
of the aorta, receptive to any

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incoming ship, needle, boat, barge, unloading
its spices, crates of dates, barrels of poisons,
Etoposide phosphate, amethyst, amaranth,
Cisplatin, amphorae of wine and olives.

I carry it secretly under my skin
because it is easier. I carry
everything under my skin, so lightly
I barely notice, watching from the ramparts

the dangerous rocky anchorage below
where goods and evils, bundled together
and tied, arrive, waiting to be unloaded
and poured out into a welcoming country.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Robert W. King
Book: Nimrod International Journal, Volume 58.2)
ASIN: B0011E9UQE
Publisher: University of Tulsa
Date (Month/Year): 2015

Cachexia

(wasting of the body due to sever chronic illness)

Today I woke up in my body

and wasn't that body anymore.

It's more like my dog—

for the most part obedient,

warming to me

when I slip it goldfish or toast,

but it sheds.

Can't get past a simple sit,

stay, turn over. House-trained, but not entirely.

This doesn't mean it's time to say goodbye.

I've realized the estrangement

is temporary, and for my own good:

My body's work to break the world

into bricks and sticks

has turned inward.

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As all the doors in the world

grow heavy

a big white bed is being put up in my heart.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Max Ritvo
ISBN: N/A
Publisher: Poets.org (Approved NSDA Website)
Weblink: https://poets.org/poem/cachexia

A Letter from Cancer

Dear Lover,

These buzzing fluorescents have you looking a little pale,
Just a little washed out.

And all this antiseptic is far from complimenting that perfume.
This linoleum will make your most stylish pair of pumps look cheap.

Sweetheart, you look tired.
I'll never understand how it is that you don't see it.

How terribly beautiful you are.
Look in the mirror.

I'm in all the dark spots.
The hallowed slopes

In your eyes and beneath them
Your color it's just so delicious.

Listen to the sound of my voice
To these sweet nothings.

I will love your everything.
Every multicolored malignancy.

Raw and heaving.
Breathe with me, bleed out with me

We will waste away together.
Hush now.

I will hold you through these tremors.
It is just the way that we dance, baby.

Listen to the music
This mutation is orchestral, this spreading so symphonic.

Split cells 2 by 2 by 4
Watch our love spread.

Lover, why do you want me dead?
I will show you heaven, baby.

Give you the stars and the sun
Those are sunspots on your lungs.

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You can't just tie a ribbon around me, cough me up.
Really now? Did you think i'd go that easy?

That I'd ever think to up and leave you.
Rest darling, lay down.

You know how I love to lay rivers
Through your shattered glass veins.

Your heart is just as big as they all said it was,
But not as strong.

All of that veined pride as I'm pumping.
I know that poker-face all too well.

You will love me.
I gave you my sun. love me.

Deadly I'll make you an angel.
Love me, I'll make you feel radiance.

You will meet me there.
In 9 months or 6 months or 3.

They try to time-stamp our love, expiration date us
But take your time. I'll wait for you.

Quite impatient as you wake on night
With a stitch in your side or wasp in your brain.

And you will know, I've come back for you.

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I will always come back for you, darling
We will look so beautiful laid out with all the wilted lilies.

They will weep for everything that you were
And for everything you will never be

Without me.
Lover, it is my understanding that you want me dead.

Fine
Die with me.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kevin Kantor
Book: Endowing Vegetables with too much Meaning (Pg 10)
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AWARD HISTORY

CO State Qualifier

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